Module 2: Product Strategy and Strategic Thinking

Detailed supplement: vision, positioning, moats, systems thinking, bet sizing, B2B strategy and a take-home strategy case

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MODULE 2 · HOW TO USE THIS SUPPLEMENT

Coverage map: what is new and what is already in the module

Read this supplement next to the main Module 2 handbook. **Extended** means the handbook has the topic and this PDF adds the deck's frame or example. **New** means the handbook did not have it.

Topic (Week 2 deck)	Handbook section	Status here
Strategy versus roadmap	2.1 (partial)	Extended: vision, strategy, bets and roadmap, with the test that a strategy changed
Vision, mission, strategy and roadmap questions	2.1	Extended: the question each one answers
Strategy is a set of choices	2.2	Extended: where to play and how to win
Positioning and moats	2.3	Extended: the five moats and the positioning sentence
Systems thinking and second-order effects	—	New: loops, incentives, bottlenecks and a worked chain
Bet sizing and resource allocation	2.4	Extended: the 70, 20, 10 split and the four-quadrant test
Kill, hold or double down	—	New: three decision rules
B2B strategy: point solution, platform, land-and-expand	2.5 (partial)	Extended: the three stages and their questions
Common strategy mistakes	—	New: five mistakes with the fix for each
Product judgment and taste	—	New: five questions a PM answers before a call
The new PM operating model	—	New: what changes when teams are small
Strategy case rubric and answer pattern	—	New: five rubric questions and the answer pattern
Live activity: strategy breakdown	—	New: a five-part product breakdown
Break-out and take-home strategy assignments	—	New: two briefs with a checklist

NOTE ON THE SOURCE

Most slides in the source deck are pictures with short labels. The labels are used here; no figures are added beyond them. The DailyDish and B2B cases are teaching scenarios.

EXTENDED · STRATEGY AND ROADMAP

Strategy is not a roadmap

Vision, mission, strategy and roadmap are connected, but each answers a different question:

Element	Question it answers	Typical content
Vision	What future are we trying to create?	A future state (the destination)
Mission	What problem do we exist to solve, and for whom?	The purpose for a defined group
Strategy	Where will we play, how will we win, and what will we not do?	Choices and trade-offs
Roadmap	Which bets ship first, in what sequence, and when?	Sequence and timing

THE TEST

If the feature list changes and the story still works, you probably did not have a strategy. A strategy explains why the work matters, so it survives a change in features.

EXTENDED · STRATEGY IS A SET OF CHOICES

Where to play and how to win

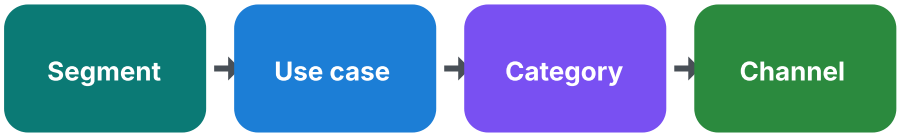
A product leader decides four things: where to play, how to win, what to build moats around, and how to allocate resources. A roadmap lists work; strategy explains why the work matters.

Where to play: narrow the field

Choice	Question to answer
Customer segment	Who has the sharpest pain and the highest willingness to change?
Use case or job	Which job matters enough to become a habit?
Category or market	Which frame helps customers understand why we matter?
Channel or geography	Where can we reach, onboard and win efficiently?

How to win: be meaningfully better on something that matters

Advantage	What it means
Better product experience	Faster, simpler, more reliable or more delightful
Better economics	A clearer return on investment, lower cost or a stronger business model
Better distribution	Reach demand that competitors cannot reach as well
Better workflow fit	Become part of the customer's natural way of working



Where to play: narrow the field

EXTENDED · POSITIONING AND MOATS

Positioning sentence and the moats that compound

Choose three things: the customer, the promise, and the differentiator. Then write the positioning sentence:

FOR [SEGMENT], OUR PRODUCT DELIVERS [VALUE] BECAUSE [DIFFERENTIATOR].

Then test it with three questions: why this customer, why this promise, and what cannot be copied easily?

Moat	How it compounds (deck)
Distribution	Reach customers faster or more cheaply than others.
Data	Usage creates insight, personalisation and product improvement.
Workflow switching cost	The product is embedded in how work gets done.
Network effects	More users create more value for every participant.
Brand and trust	Trust reduces decision friction and improves conversion.

RULE OF THUMB

A feature can be copied. A compounding system is harder to copy. Ask which moat gets stronger as the product grows.

NEW · SYSTEMS THINKING

Watch loops, not lines

Great PMs optimise the system, not a single screen. The deck's loop example for a marketplace: better seller tools lead to more sellers, which gives better selection, more buyers, and more gross merchandise value. Then the loop starts again.

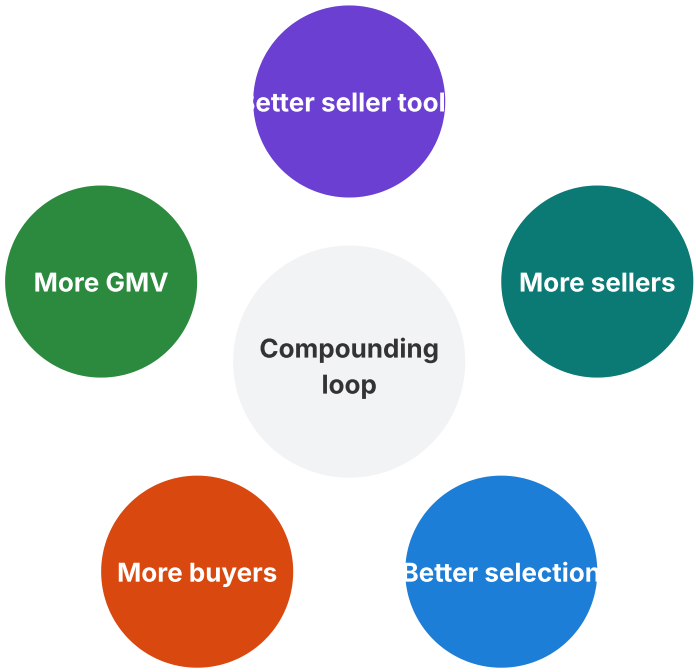
Principle	What it means
See second-order effects	Today's change can create tomorrow's results.
Watch incentives	People respond to incentives, not announcements.
Fix bottlenecks, not symptoms	Improve the constraint that unlocks the whole system.
Measure the whole system	Use leading and lagging metrics across the loop.

First-order versus second-order effects

Example: lower seller onboarding friction. The chain is: more sellers sign up (first-order); selection improves (second-order); buyer conversion rises (system effect); gross merchandise value and retention improve (business outcome).

WATCH OUT

Optimising a local metric can hurt the wider system. Ask what happens next, and then what happens after that.



The marketplace loop from the deck

EXTENDED · BET SIZING

Fund conviction in stages

Product leaders fund conviction in stages. The deck's split is a useful starting point, not a rule:

Share	Use	What it protects or tests
70 percent	Core	Protects the current business
20 percent	Growth	Expands into adjacent demand
10 percent	Options	Learns cheaply before scaling

Score every bet on four questions: what is the upside, what evidence exists (confidence), is the bet reversible, and how long until we learn?

Quadrant	Upside and confidence	Action
Big bet	High upside, high confidence	Commit talent and time
Pilot	High upside, low confidence	Learn before scaling
Optimise	Low upside, high confidence	Improve efficiently
Avoid	Low upside, low confidence	Do not distract the team

Confidence comes from usage depth, retention, customer pull and willingness to pay.



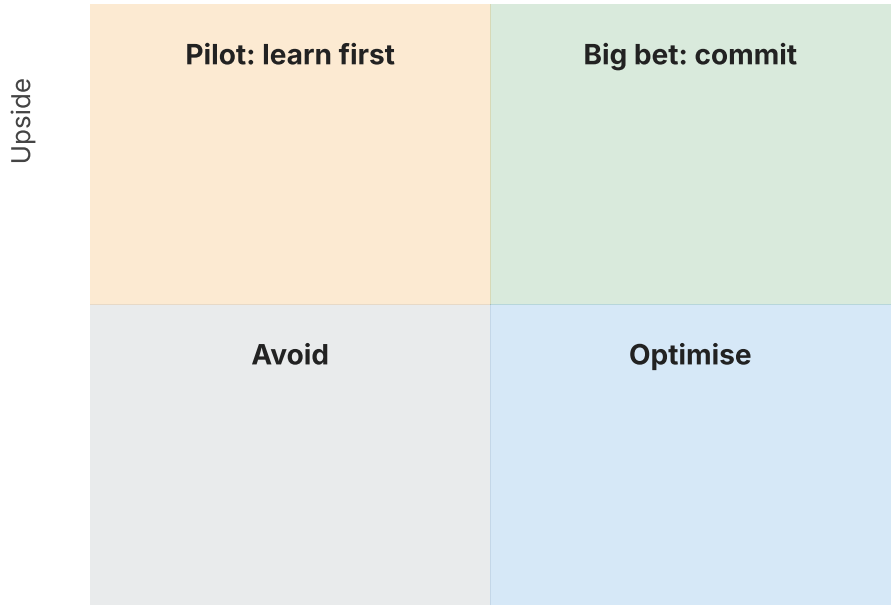
Bet split from the deck: 70, 20 and 10 percent

NEW · REPEATED DECISION

When to kill, hold or double down

Resource allocation is a repeated decision, not a yearly memo. Review each bet against the same four measures: usage depth, retention, revenue quality and strategic fit.

Decision	Use it when	Example signal
Kill	The signal is weak, the cost is rising, or there is no strategic fit	No retained core after the pilot
Hold	The signal is mixed, you need more evidence, and the decision is reversible	Good trial use, weak repeat use
Double down	Usage is deep, economics are improving, and the bet strengthens the moat	Retained users who pay and invite others



Upside and confidence decide the action

EXTENDED · B2B STRATEGY

Point solution, platform, land-and-expand

Stage	What it does	Questions to answer
1. Point solution	Solves one acute pain with fast return on investment and easier adoption	What is the wedge?
2. Platform	Owns a broader workflow, shares data across modules, and has higher contract value and switching cost	What expands naturally?
3. Land-and-expand	Win one team, prove value, then expand seats, workflows and modules over time	Where does data compound?

The wedge gets you in. The workflow keeps you in.



B2B path: wedge, workflow, expansion

NEW · COMMON MISTAKES

Five strategy mistakes and the fix

Mistake	Why it fails	Fix
1. Confusing roadmap with strategy	A feature list is not a choice about where to win	Write the choice first, then the list
2. Serving everyone	Broad targeting weakens positioning	Pick one segment to solve for first
3. No moat thinking	Value that does not compound is easy to copy	Name the moat that gets stronger over time
4. Scaling too early	Big bets without evidence waste resources	Pilot first; scale on signal
5. Optimising local metrics	A short-term win can damage the wider system	Watch the loop and the guardrails

Great product leaders reduce strategic error before they increase output. Choice over activity, focus over breadth, evidence over hope.

NEW · PRODUCT JUDGMENT AND TASTE

Choose well with incomplete information

Judgment is choosing well with incomplete information. Taste is knowing what good looks like before the data is perfect. Before a call, answer five questions:

Question	What it checks
User truth	What pain is real?
Product intuition	What experience feels obvious?
Market context	Why now?
Business logic	How does it create durable value?
Execution realism	What can the team actually ship well?

NEW · OPERATING MODEL

How the PM role is changing

Teams are getting smaller and PMs have more leverage. The shift:

Before	Now
Larger teams, slower handoffs	Smaller teams, higher agency
PM as coordinator	PM as decision-maker and builder-partner
Research, design and execution more siloed	PM, design and engineering work closer together
Learning cycles measured in weeks	Learning cycles measured in days

Less status reporting and feature brokering; more decision-making, synthesis, prioritisation and quality setting. As leverage rises, the edge shifts from output to judgment.

NEW · STRATEGIC INTERVIEWS

The strategy case rubric

Interviewers test judgment under ambiguity, not framework names. Answer five questions, in this order:

1. **Clarify the goal:** which outcome matters: growth, retention, revenue, quality or risk?
2. **Choose the segment:** who is the sharpest user or buyer to solve for first?
3. **Name the trade-off:** what will you not do, delay or ignore?
4. **Defend the bet:** why this path now, and what evidence supports it?
5. **Define success:** which leading metric, guardrail and learning signal will you track?

ANSWER PATTERN

Goal → segment → choice → trade-off → metric. A strong answer is structured, commercial and opinionated, but still testable.

The deck's five-step interview sequence is: clarify the goal, choose the segment, find the wedge, explain the moat, and size the bet.

NEW · LIVE ACTIVITY

Break down a product you use

Pick a product you use every week. Answer five questions about it:

Element	Question
1. Target segment	Who is this built for?
2. Wedge	Why do users start?
3. Moat	What gets stronger over time?
4. Current bet	Where are they doubling down?
5. Stop doing	What should they cut?

The deck's example is a 10-minute grocery delivery app. Use your own product for the exercise.

ASSIGNMENTS

Two strategy briefs

Break-out (35 minutes): DailyDish

You are a product manager at a consumer company building a recipe discovery and meal planning app. Competitors already exist. Users enjoy finding recipes, but most stop using the app after a few days. They save recipes they never cook, and make meal plans they never follow. Leadership wants a daily companion that helps people decide what to eat, shop efficiently, cook consistently and reduce food waste.

Task: define a product strategy that turns this into a habit-forming, high-retention product. Use the five-question rubric.

Take-home: corporate learning platform (B2B SaaS)

You are the first product manager at a B2B SaaS company in corporate learning and employee training. Define a product strategy for the next two to three years:

1. Pick the first customer segment (startups, mid-sized companies or enterprises).
2. Size the opportunity: how big, how often used, how painful, and why customers would pay for a better solution.
3. Select the core problem to solve deeply.
4. Describe your moats: data, integrations, network effects (IT, employees, HR teams), switching costs or brand.
5. Describe your land-and-expand strategy: the small first use case, the initial buyer, how you create internal pull, and what triggers expansion.

SELF-CHECK

Did you name a segment and a wedge? Did you say what you will not do? Is each moat tied to a mechanism? Is each metric linked to a decision?

Quiz with answers

1. What question does the roadmap answer that the strategy does not?
   Answer: which bets ship first, in what sequence, and when. Strategy answers where to play and how to win.
2. What are the three parts of the B2B path?
   Answer: point solution, platform, land-and-expand.
3. Name the four questions of bet sizing.
   Answer: upside, confidence, reversibility and time to signal.
4. What is a second-order effect?
   Answer: a later result that follows from the first-order change, such as better selection after more sellers join.
5. When should you kill a bet?
   Answer: when the signal is weak, the cost is rising, or there is no strategic fit.
6. What does the answer pattern for a strategy case look like?
   Answer: goal, segment, choice, trade-off, metric.

MODULE 2 · FINAL

Completion checklist

Completion checklist

Done	Item
☐	Read the coverage map and marked the new topics
☐	Wrote a positioning sentence for a product you use
☐	Mapped one loop, with a second-order effect
☐	Sized one bet with the four questions
☐	Completed the DailyDish break-out with the rubric
☐	Completed the take-home brief with a moat and an expansion path
☐	Answered the quiz without notes